

bargain prices are Robert Kacher Selections, Winebow, Kermit Lynch, Terry Theise, and Polaner.

3. Know your wine type

Do some research on your personal tastes. Do you like oaked or unoaked wines? Do you prefer full- or medium-bodied wines? Do you enjoy off-dry or dry wines? These simple indicators will help your sommelier and/or wine retailer identify great-value wines that will suit your tastes and your wallet.

4. Keep it in the family

For many great wine producers, wine making is the family business. Expertise and traditions are passed down for generations, so following a wine producer's "family tree," particularly for the new or special labels, is one way to find great-value wines that are created in a style you trust. Bill Arbios, winemaker in Sonoma County, is an excellent example. After many years with Lyeth, Bill branched out with his wife to create two smaller labels: Arbios and Praxis. His knowledge of the Sonoma region and his relationship with superior growers made it all possible.

5. Blind date

Host a blind tasting featuring wines from a single region. Lining up wines from a specific region, without regard to price, can be an eye-opening exercise. Oftentimes, high prices are more an indicator of a winery's real estate value than the quality of the wine it produces. It pays to explore the wide array of styles and producers that a region has to offer, rather than simply chasing the big names. You are more likely to find your perfect match. This would make a nice activity to do with more people—make a party out of it.

6. Grape gurus know best

Restaurants and retailers that specialize in boutique producers are your best resource for value wine suggestions. Boutique wineries offer some of the best value/quality ratios out there, but these wines are often limited and hard to find. Boutique-savvy wine retailers are never short on suggestions of new wines to try. Simply have a producer, style, or region that you like in mind and let the experts pair you with your perfect wine.

— Myscha Theriault